CENTRE FOR CIVIL SOCIETY AND GOVERNANCE
THE UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG

HKU SLG Programme
Taster Lecture: Policy Challenges for Sustainable Transitions

Part 1 - Unpacking Sustainability: Core Characteristics and Policy Challenges

Dr. Vivian Chu

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SLGP Master of Social Sciences in the field of Sustainability Leadership and Governance 永續發展領導力與治理碩士課程

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BLOG

Career Talk cum Admission Briefing: Master of Social Sciences in Sustainability Leadership and Governance 2026-27

Many may think that they work primarily on ESG reporting—which is in fact only a very small part of what our graduates do! We are pleased to have Season Ho, Udara Senevirathne, and Ruoqi Zhu 朱若绮 Zhu sharing with us how they embed sustainability knowledge and skill sets into their everyday work.

READ MORE

Course title: **SLGP 7007 Governance and Policy for Sustainability Transition**

What was covered last week (Lecture 1):

1. Governance: Modes of governance

Extended case study + reflection

2. Basic definitions and concepts:

- Public Policy
- Principles for sustainability policy making
- Policy tools

3. Sustainability transition and policy framing

Content for Part 1

- Fundamental concepts
  - Public policy
    - Sustainability policy
  - Policy-making process
- Characteristics of sustainability issues that create inherent challenges to policy-making
- Policy framing

What is Public Policy?

"Whatever governments choose to do or not to do" (Anderson, 2000: 2)

State intervention is at the root of the conception of public policies

"A relatively stable, purposive course of action followed by an actor or set of actors in dealing with a problem or matter of concern… developed by government bodies and officials" (Anderson, 2000: 4)

What is **Public** Policy?

"A relatively stable, purposive course of action followed by an actor or set of actors in dealing with a problem or matter of concern… developed by government bodies and officials" (Anderson, 2000: 4)

What is implied?

- Not random behavior or chance occurrences
- Consist of courses of action taken over time (not separate, discrete decisions)
- Goals can be loosely stated, providing general direction rather than precise targets

"Whatever governments choose to do or not to do" (Anderson, 2000: 2)

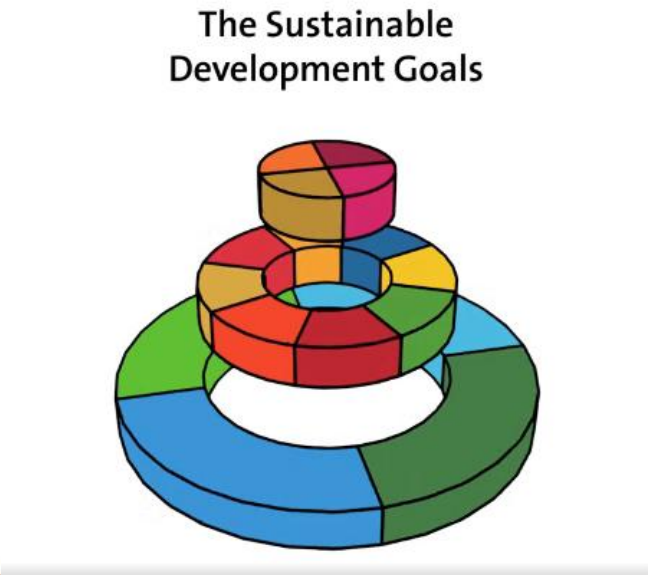
the making of decisions on policy issues and the 'Not making' of decisions –

Non-decisions / inaction (Howlett, 2001)

Policies for sustainability

Environmental policies:

- government action that affects or attempts to affect environmental quality or the use of natural resources
- pursue environmental goals and objectives, and to use tools to achieve these goals



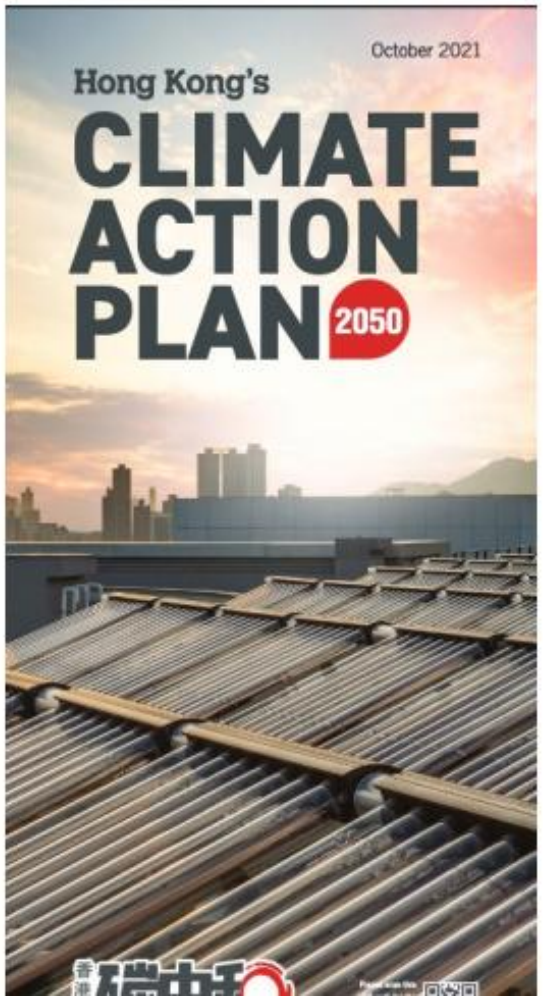
Credit: Stockholm Resilience Centre

Policies for sustainability

Also includes social concerns

- Policies related to society and the economy – poverty, employment, inclusivity/ inequality, vulnerable groups etc…
- Social equity and justice
- Policies that contribute towards resilient futures

These are all policies relevant to sustainability



Cap. 358 Water Pollution Control Ordinance

To control the pollution of the waters of Hong Kong.

[1 April 1981] *L.N. 87 of 1981*
(Format changes—E.R. 3 of 2018)

Part I

Preliminary

1. Short title

This Ordinance may be cited as the Water Pollution Control Ordinance.

2. Interpretation

(1) In this Ordinance, unless the context otherwise requires—

Appeal Board (上訴委員會) means an Appeal Board constituted under Part VI;

Authority (監督) means the Director of Environmental Protection; *(Replaced 83 of 1993 s. 2)*

What is Public Policy-making?

- the making of decisions on policy issues.

- the failure to make decisions - *Non-decisions / inaction* (remain stuck in status-quo)

(Howlett, 2001)

Policy-making process: what is it like?

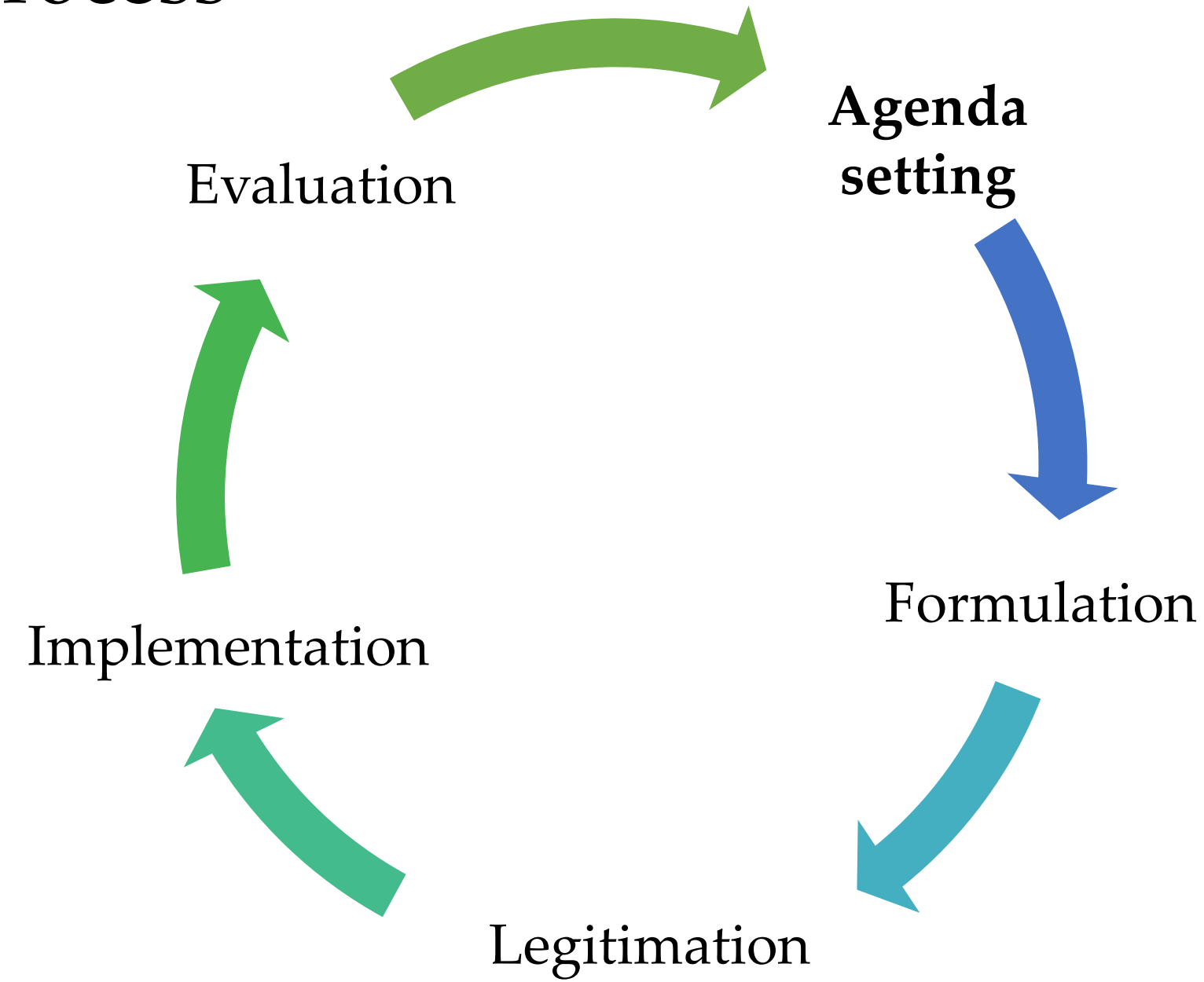
1. A problem is detected

2. Scientists **get the facts right** on the problems and the causes, then propose a solution

3. Decision-makers design policies **based on these facts**

4. Administrative authorities implement policies

Policy-making process (cyclical model)



Vig and Kraft, 2012

"[c]limatologists can tell us what is happening to the planet and why it is happening,
they can even say with some confidence what will happen in the years to come.

What we do about all of this, though,
depends on what we think is right, what we value, what matters to us.

You cannot find that sort of stuff in an ice core.
You have to think your way through it."

Philosopher James Garvey (2008: 2) in **Evans 2012 Chapter 1 (p 13)**

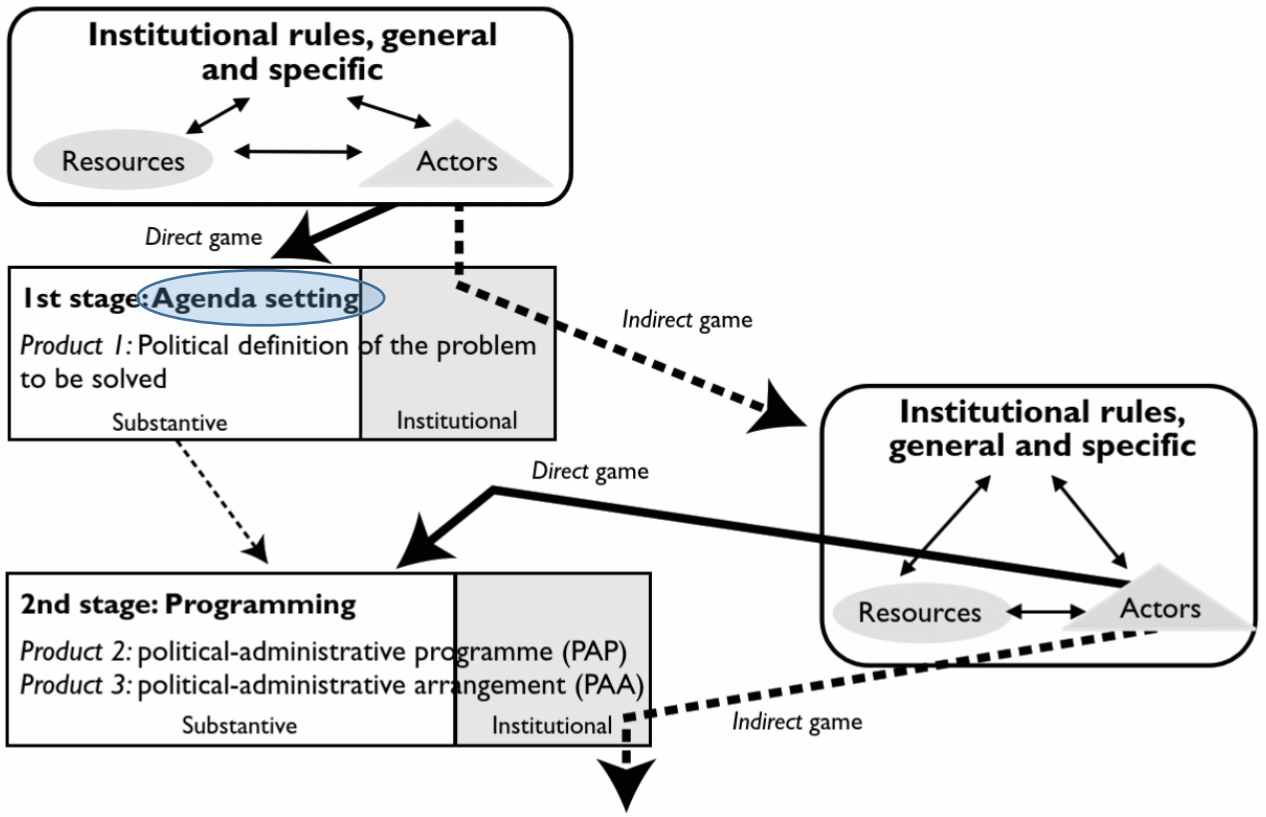
Is there a better way to depict public policy-making?

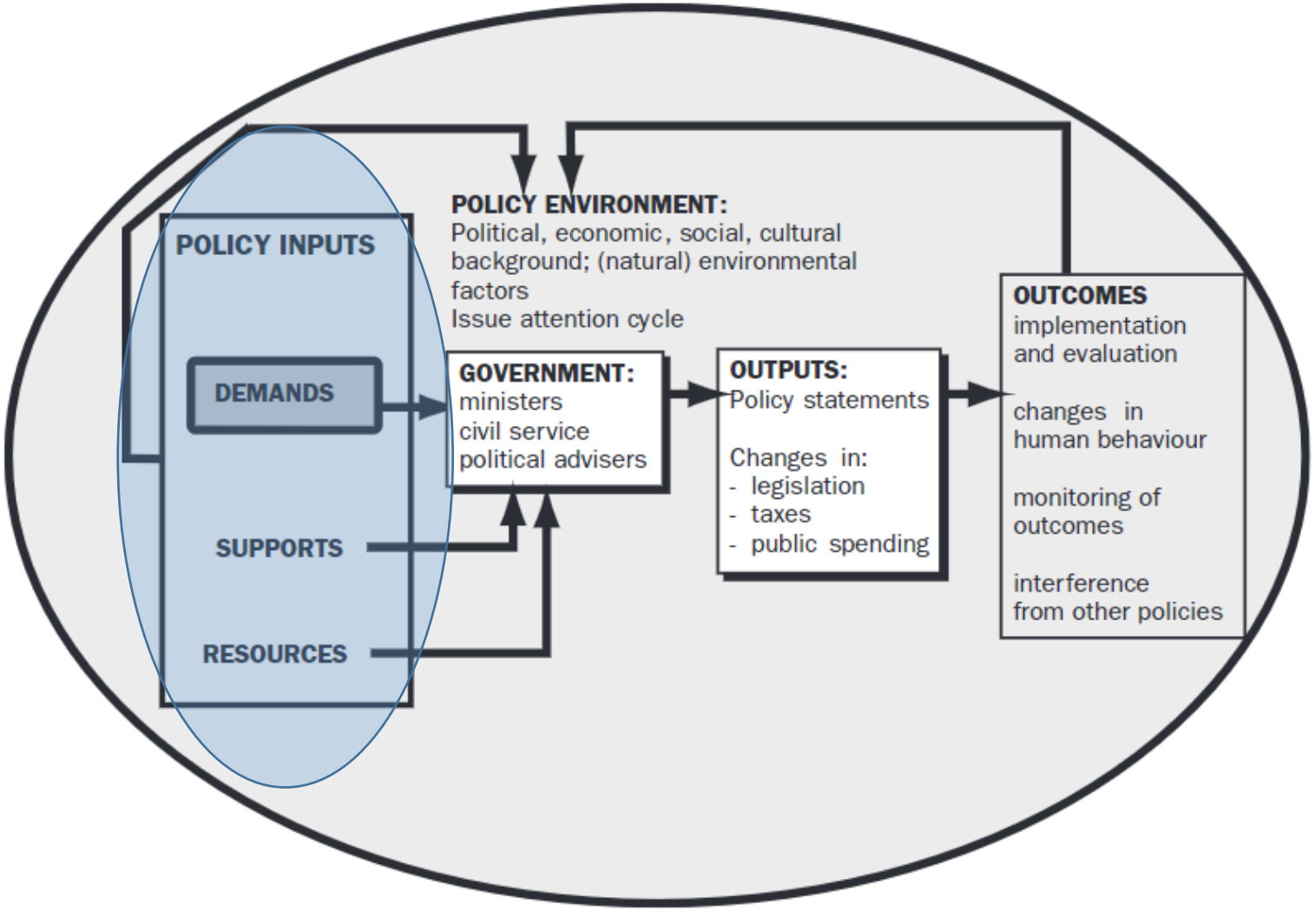
On-going processes of negotiation and bargaining between multiple actors over time.

*"At each stage in the policy process, **new actors** may **appear** in the policy arena (or **disappear** from it) and/or actors who were previously in the minority may – alone or by means of (new) coalitions with others – use (new) institutional rules and exploit (new) combinations of resources to **finally assert their interests**, **ideas** and **rights**.*
This may then translate into a significant modification of the policy"

(Knoepfel et al, 2007: 117)

Figure 6.2: The direct and indirect influence of the triangle of actors on the first two stages of a public policy (postulate no 2)





(Roberts, 2011: 144)

Figure 6.1 ***The policy-making process at government level***

Demands from various sectors

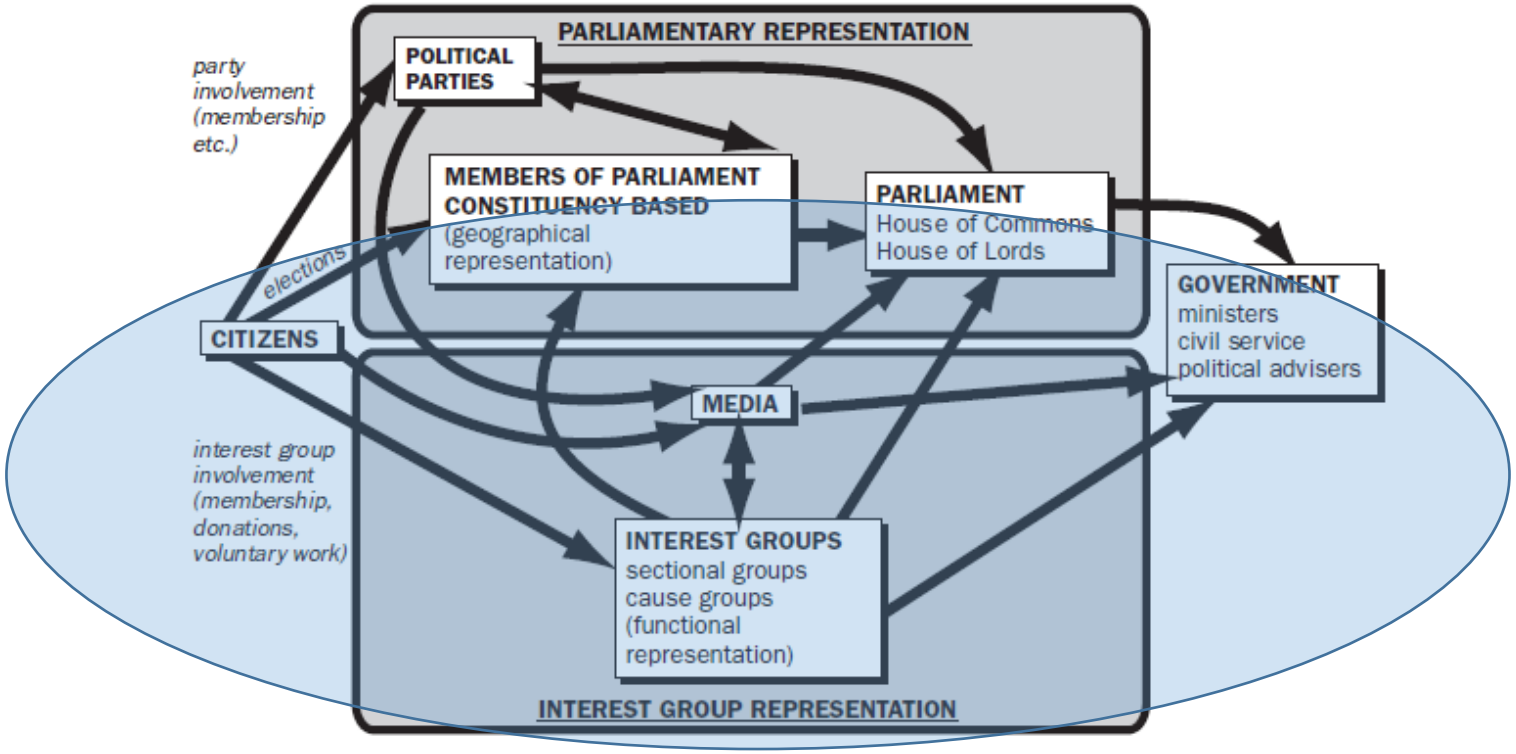


Figure 6.3 *Interest groups and representation*

(Roberts, 2011:147)

Reasons for non-decision

E.g. The nature of the issue:

Hard issue

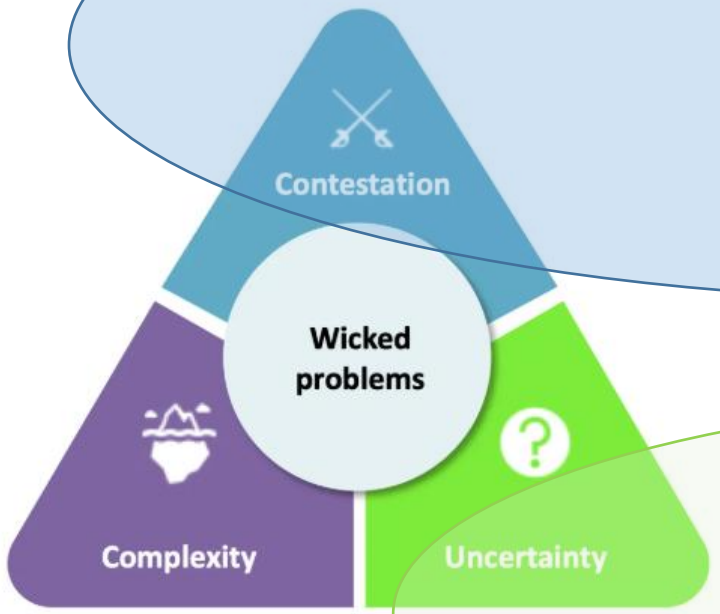
- The issue only involves a **limited number of specialized policy actors**

Closed network

- Existing policy actors have a high ability to **prevent new members** from **entering into policy debates** and discourses

(Howlett, 2001)

Common **characteristics of sustainability issues** that create inherent <u>challenges to policy-making (</u>and their effectiveness)



Contestation: the degree of normative divergence related to a policy issue. Seen as the result of divergent claims, values and framings, or the inherent conflicts of interest resulting from social pluralism and stakeholder divergence. Can restrict diffusion patterns, and lead to the refusal of a technically feasible innovation or a proven regulatory solution, due to prevailing norms and values.

Complexity: caused by the multi-scalar and multi-dimensional nature of societal problems to be addressed by policy, e.g. where multiple actors, policy domains, and governance levels need to cooperate. Related to the fact that novel technological or institutional solutions may require the restructuring of the socio-technical system.

Uncertainty: limited knowledge about the availability or feasibility of potential solutions, or the fact that multiple technological and/or institutional solutions seem to be possible and promising without indication which works best for tackling a challenge in time. Can reduce legitimacy and broad acceptance of effective solutions, or set back their development and diffusion.

Source: Kelleher, 2023

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Source: Kelleher, 2023

1. Difficulties in drawing the boundary

A) Which sectors/departments?

Which departments?

- Unclear distribution of responsibilities
- Silo mentality

Which sectors?

- need to engage with range of sectors, address conflicting needs/concerns

B) Which jurisdiction?

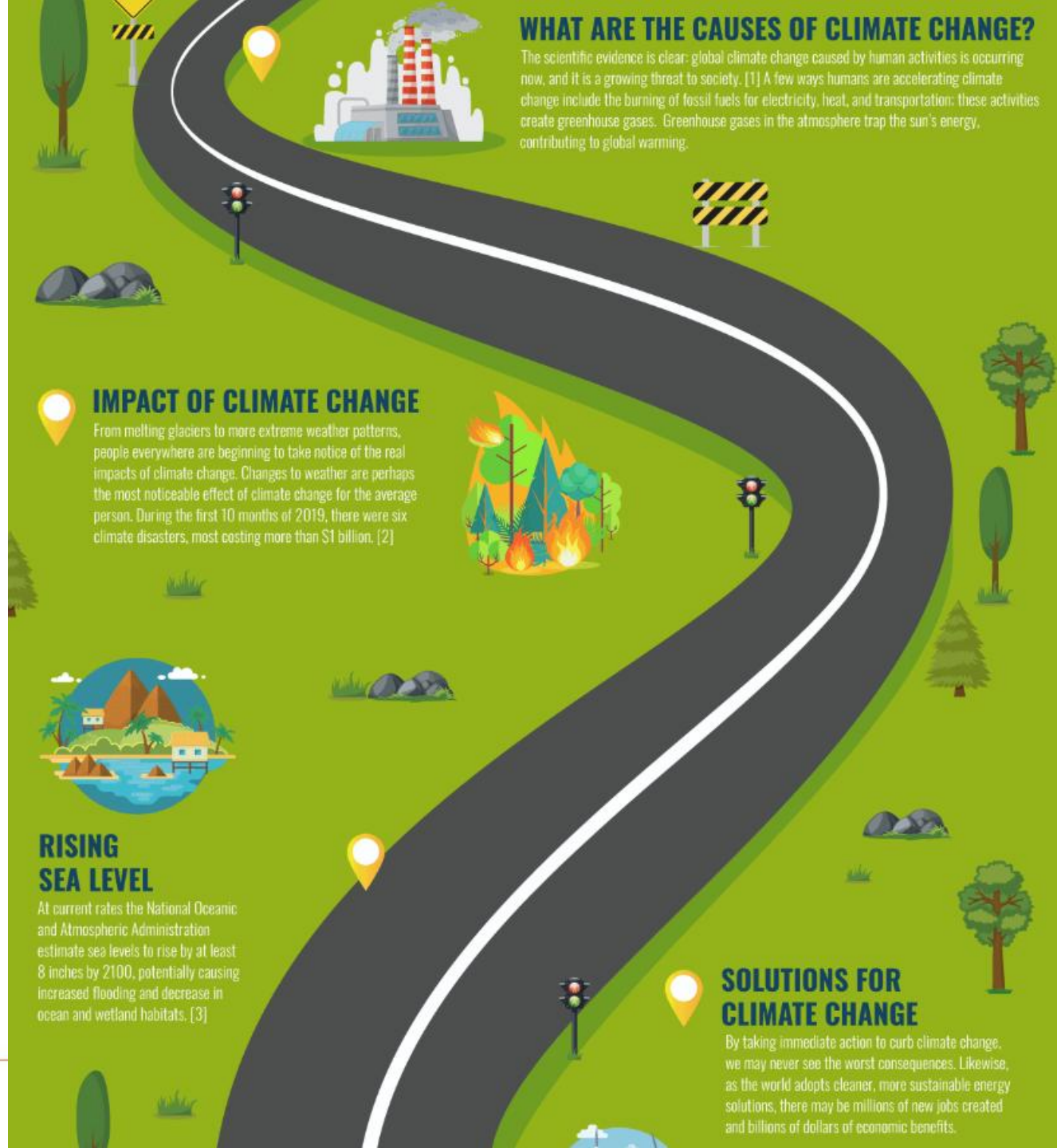
Environmental problems do not respect political boundaries

Current systems breed competition, not cooperation

2. Mismatch between people who are making the decisions and those affected by the consequences

What examples can you think of?

Source: Terrapass, 2024
[Climate Change Battle: Causes, Effects, and Solutions]



3. What is right/what is wrong?

Subjectivity and a lack of certainty

- Solutions are rarely black and white
- Complex causes, hard to trace back to original causes
- Multiple intermediary processes between sources and harm

Policy framing

Framing is a way of structuring or presenting a problem or an issue

Policy framing as a concept

- Premise

that different individuals can observe the same social and natural phenomena and necessarily arrive at different conclusions

- Places an emphasis on the dynamics of change and the constantly changing and contested notion of policy reality.

(Badie et al., 2011)

Policy framing

The policy framing process involves policy actors

(a) confronting a situation where the understanding is problematic and uncertain,

(b) creating an understanding or story that helps analyze and make sense of the situation,

and (c) then acting (and persuading others to act) on it.

(Badie et al., 2011)

How is the understanding of climate change influenced by its framing

- Impacting what/who?
- Global warming→ Climate change?
- A local/global issue?

- How can a sense of urgency be added?

TABLE 8.2 Climate change frames used in environmental education programs, adapted from K. C. Busch, "Polar Bears or People?" and Anne Armstrong, "Climate Change Communication in Environmental Education"

FRAME CATEGORIES	EXAMPLES
Global impacts	Warmer temperatures are causing other changes around the world, such as melting glaciers and stronger storms.[24]
Local/proximal	Addressing climate change in ways that the audience has actually seen—more insect outbreaks, devastating wildfires, and how forests are being managed.[25]
Science based	Average global sea temperature has been rising gradually over several decades, 0.7°C in the past thirty years alone, which is generally believed among the scientific community to be due to global warming.[26]
Human-impacts based	Climate-related changes can make it difficult for Inuit hunters to reach the places where they hunt.[27]
Collective solutions	Pointing out things that are going on right now that people are doing; for instance, in our county, many businesses and organizations have actually have been very successful promoting renewable energy.[28]
Individual solutions	Deforestation to plant palm plantations adds to climate change, so make sure to buy products labeled with "Roundtable of Sustainable Palm Oil (RSPO)" and help promote sustainable palm production.[29]

Doomsday, tipping point	"Climate Catastrophe Will Hit Tropics around 2020, Rest of World around 2047, Study Says"[18]

Climate mis/disinformation

Disinformation→ deliberately seeks to mislead people

Misleading content (e.g. sponsored by those with interests in fossil fuels)

- Particularly powerful on social media
- Cognitive bias, social bias + algorithms designed to show us tailored content

  - Cognitive bias: more likely to believe information that seems true
  - Social bias: more likely to believe information from friends

Mis/ disinformation

petroleum energy Humble supplies—if
d! To meet the nation's growing needs
ne America's Leading Energy Company,
in many forms—to help heat our homes,
of versatile chemicals. Stop at a Humble
ring. Sign is the World's First Choice!

HUMBLE
OIL & REFINING COMPANY
America's Leading Energy company

Lies they tell our children

"I don't have a future."
With tears streaming down her face, a 13-year-old girl made this bleak assessment to

in the U.S. are less than half what they were from 1957 to 1967.
■ The amount of unhealthy sulfur dioxide

you the earth was warming...

1991

Doomsday is cancelled.

1993

Apocalypse no

or the first half of 1992, America was inun-
ated by the media with dire predictions of glob-
warming catastrophes, all of which seemed to
e aimed at heating up the rhetoric from the
arth Summit in Rio de Janeiro last June.

trations of greenhouse gases. And it arises again when climate prediction models are used to conclude Earth's temperature will climb drastically in the next century and—based on such models—to propose policy decisions that could

1997

Science: what we know and don't know

As the debate over climate change
the past century may bear a "fingerprint"

2000

Unsettled Science

Illustration: Guardian Design

2003-06

202

Climate crimes

This article is more than 4 years old

The forgotten oil ads that told us climate change was nothing

Since the 1980s, fossil fuel firms have run ads touting climate denial messages – many of which they'd now like us to forget. Here's our visual guide

By Geoffrey Supran and Naomi Oreskes

Advertisement

The Guardian

Center for Countering DIGITAL HATE

THE TOXIC TEN

How ten fringe publishers fuel 69% of digital climate change denial

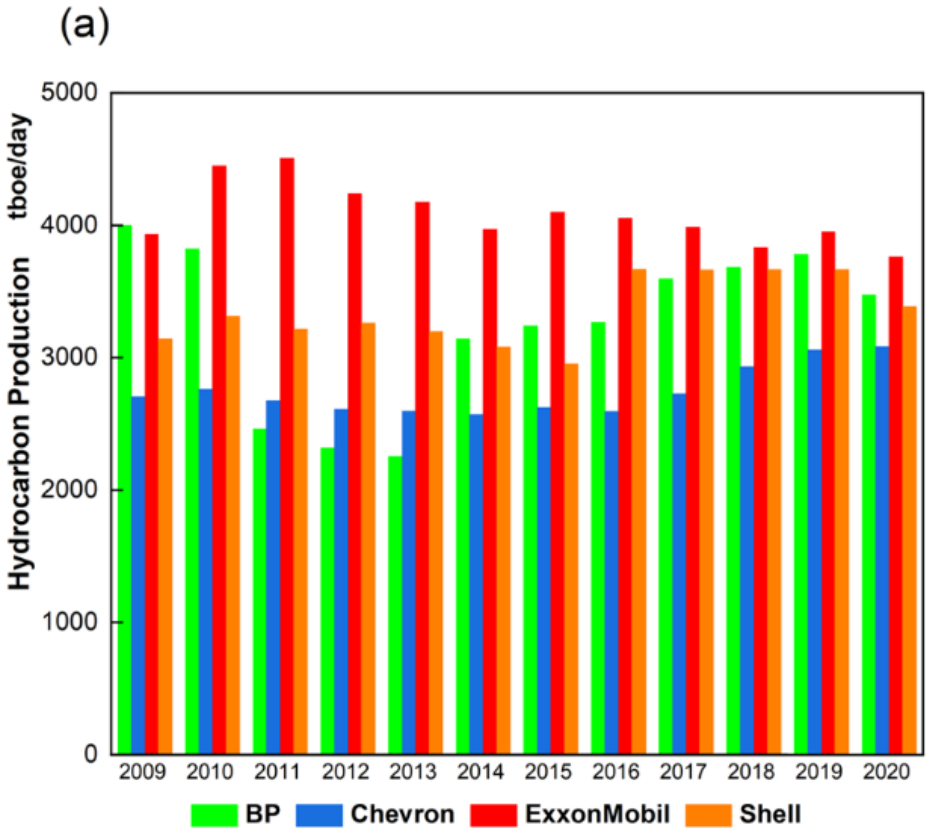
Article Nov, 2021

Types of mis/disinformation

- Climate denial: deny climate change is real, downplay severity, claim it is 'natural'
- Climate delay: aim to obstruct or hinder action. Dispute feasibility/necessity of action based on cost or uncertainty (job losses, economic harm)
- Climate conspiracy narratives: aimed at delegitimising climate science, policies and activism by suggesting part of a hidden agenda (e.g., climate change as a hoax to increase government control)
- Greenwashing…

Greenwashing

Corporations highlight their positive contributions and ignore the environmental harm that they cause (Kraft, 2010)



No major decrease in hydrocarbon production

(Li et al. 2022)

Who gains?

Protects fossil fuel interests and business as usual scenarios

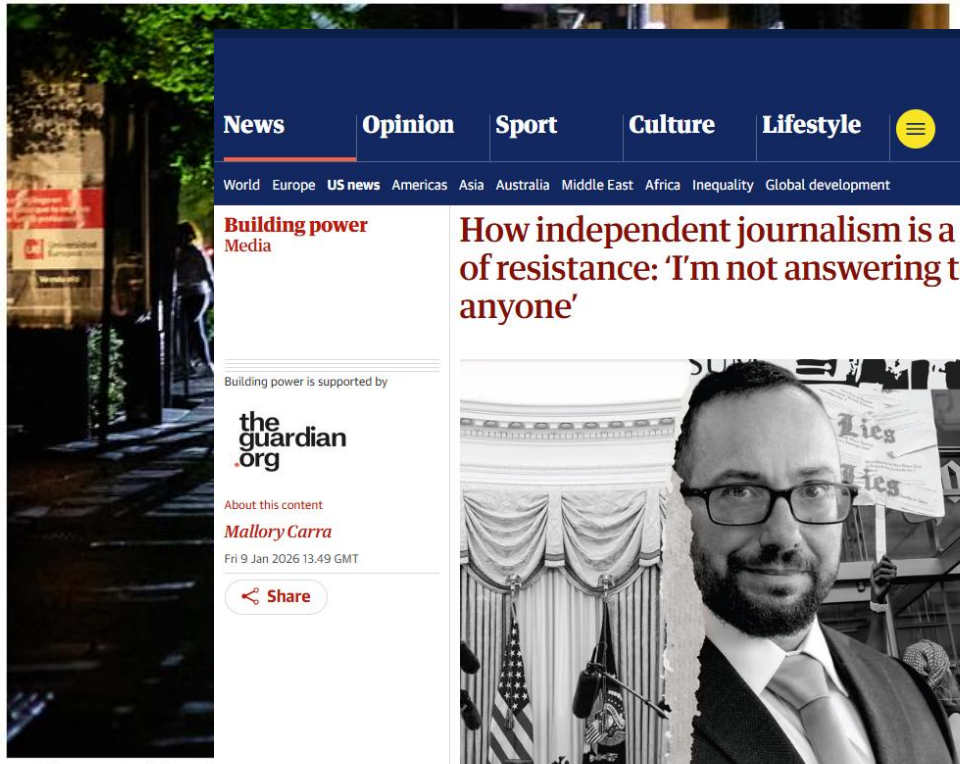
- Seek to extend the viability of fossil fuels and maintain economic gains
- Gains in revenue, influence or support by exploiting the attention received
- Exacerbate existing tensions

- Undermines public trust in science, delays policy response and pits people against each other

What's being done?

Climate misinformation turning crisis into catastrophe, report says

False claims obstructing climate action, say researchers, amid calls for climate lies to be criminalised



There were false cl
Photograph: NurPhot

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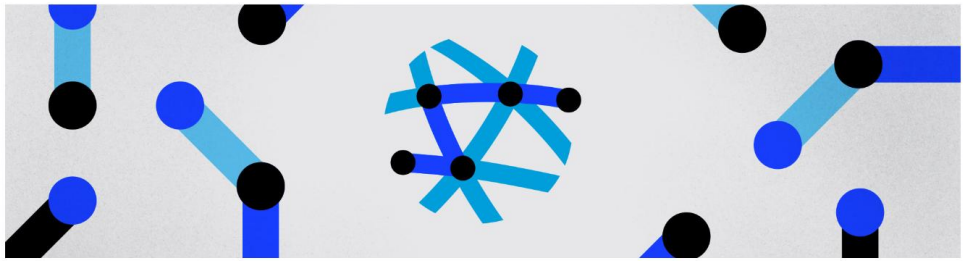

Information Integrity

The Information Ecosystem in the Digital Age

An incredible self-own ...

... in 1936, John Scott, son of the late Guardian owner and legendary editor CP Scott, did something unheard of for a media heir: he gave up his stake for the greater good.

After inheriting the newspaper, Scott renounced all financial benefit - bar his salary - in the Guardian (worth £1m at the time and around £62m today) and passed ownership over to the newly formed Scott Trust. The Trust would evolve to have one key mission: to secure the financial and editorial independence of the Guardian in perpetuity.

That means the Guardian can't be bought. Not by private equity, not by a conglomerate, and definitely not by a billionaire looking for a political mouthpiece.

Our independence means we can say what we want, report on who we want, challenge who we want, and stand up at a time when others are sitting down.

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HKU SLG Programme
Taster Lecture: Policy Challenges for Sustainable Transitions

Part 2 - Climate Technology and Mitigation Deterrence:
How Direct Air Capture Narratives Shape Public Expectations

Prof. Ian Li

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